

States **ORISSA**

Plunder of the EARTH

A mega-scam waits to be unearthed in the mineral-rich poor state as a probe runs into a nexus between miners, bureaucrats and politicians

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IRON ORE MINES IN KEONJHAR DISTRICT

| By Farzand Ahmed |

The clean image of the Naveen Patnaik Government could well be consigned to a bottomless pit if recent charges about the organised plunder of the state's precious mineral wealth manage to stick. As allegations of crores of rupees changing hands to permit illegal mining began flying thick and fast, the BJP Government ordered an inquiry by the Vigilance Directorate which has now exposed a syndicate-like nexus between politicians, mine operators and bureaucrats.

The directorate has filed an FIR

against Indrani Patnaik who belongs to the family of former Congress minister Niranjan Patnaik (a relative of former chief minister J.B. Patnaik, now governor of Assam) and her Keonjhar-based company. If the scam has so far turned out to be "mother of all scams in the country", the predictable chaos in the Assembly and outside has added yet more contro-

versy to the muddy politics of Orissa.

For nine years, the BJP was a ruling partner under whose nose the "loot" was going on, but none of its ministers, some of whom held important portfolios, found anything wrong. Now that they are in the Opposition, they are baying for the Government's blood. The chief minister's alter-ego and Rajya Sabha mem-

THE OPPOSITION SAYS THE NAVEEN PATNAIK GOVERNMENT FIRST REJECTED AN INQUIRY BY A HOUSE COMMITTEE AND WHEN A CBI PROBE WAS SOUGHT, IT ORDERED A VIGILANCE PROBE.

